Weekly digests · Week 2026-W43 · 19 October 2026 – 25 October 2026

# Anger deepens as Israeli incursions, Suwayda rift and diesel crisis converge

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## 1. The week at a glance

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1. Average public tone fell sharply to -0.30 from -0.15 the week before, far angrier than outlets' mild -0.06.
2. Israeli incursions in Quneitra and the south stayed the week's most discussed story for a 40th straight update, alongside a sharp rise in attention to Suwayda and the Druze.
3. People's anger over Israeli actions and Suwayda ran far hotter than the more measured language used in media and expert coverage, which described armed Druze groups mainly as 'outlaw groups'.
4. A diesel crisis in Aleppo and Idlib drove some of the sharpest public anger of the week despite emergency shipments, while transitional justice news drew unusually calm, even mildly hopeful, reactions.
5. Kurdish-language posts kept pressing education and identity demands that barely registered in Arabic-language coverage of integration talks.

## 2. What people said

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Public attention this week was dominated by two interlinked crises: Israeli military activity in the south, which held its place as the most-discussed story across all 40 updates, and a sharp escalation in Suwayda, where the Druze share of discussion rose by three points and tone fell to a deeply negative -0.45. Overall public tone dropped from -0.15 to -0.30, driven largely by these two themes plus a worsening diesel shortage in Aleppo and Idlib that posters described with mockery and accusations of government hoarding.

Where outlets stayed comparatively measured, describing Israeli incursions and Sweida blockades in careful, often official language (outlet tone -0.20 to -0.40 but generally less visceral than public posts), ordinary posters expressed far sharper anger, especially over the Sarout chants controversy, the viral Al Arabiya interview on Druze identity, and the disputed Rankous ISIS raid, where public skepticism of the official account outpaced most outlets' coverage.

Comparing public talk with the media and experts' own focus shows real gaps in both directions: coverage stressed a cluster of financing deals (the START fund, a letter of credit, Gulf pledges) as a turning point for recovery, something ordinary posters barely engaged with beyond skepticism about corruption; meanwhile the open sectarian hostility in public comments toward Druze leader Hikmat al-Hijri, and the strength of public disbelief in the Rankous narrative, went further than the more neutral framing used in most outlet reporting.

Language and community divides remained visible: Kurdish-language posts from Qamishli and Rojava University emphasized identity and education rights with firm, determined framing, largely separate from Arabic-language coverage of administrative integration talks, while Turkish-language commenters combined anti-Israel sentiment with distrust of their own government's regional posture.

Transitional justice stood out as a rare point of calm, with Assad's death sentence drawing mostly symbolic, low-emotion reactions (+0.05), and DNA identification of missing persons bringing cautious hope rather than anger, a contrast to the anger dominating most other themes this week.

### The week's stories

- **Israeli incursions, bulldozing and military exercises continue in Quneitra and the south**: The week's most persistently discussed story, appearing in all 40 updates, with public anger notably sharper than official and outlet language.
- **Suwayda-Damascus highway blockade and Barrack's captagon remarks deepen rift**: Marked a sharp escalation in the Suwayda crisis, combining a full highway blockade with US envoy remarks that inflamed sectarian divisions.
- **Tensions persist in Suwayda amid checkpoint blockades and a heated TV debate on Druze identity**: A viral Al Arabiya interview triggered some of the week's harshest sectarian backlash, with coordination signals around amplification worth watching.
- **Diesel crisis deepens despite emergency shipments to Aleppo and Idlib**: Drove some of the week's most negative public tone (-0.60), reflecting mounting distrust of government economic management.
- **Rankous security operation sparks controversy over ISIS claims and information blackout**: Public skepticism of the official narrative, including a notable denial, exceeded that reflected in most outlet coverage.
- **Damascus court sentences Assad to death, Interpol request filed**: A rare moment of mildly positive, low-emotion public reaction amid an otherwise angry week.

### Themes this week

| Theme | Share of discussion | People | Outlets | Stories |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Israel and the south | 10% (+4 pts) | Leaning negative | Leaning negative | 11 |
| Suwayda and the Druze | 5% (+3 pts) | Leaning negative | Leaning negative | 11 |
| International relations | 4% (+1 pts) | Mostly neutral | Mostly neutral | 21 |
| Economy and services | 4% (-2 pts) | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 14 |
| Society and daily life | 4% (+2 pts) | Leaning negative | Leaning negative | 7 |
| Security and violence | 3% (+0 pts) | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 16 |
| North-east and the Kurdish question | 2% (-4 pts) | Mostly neutral | Mostly neutral | 9 |
| Transitional justice | 1% (-7 pts) | Mostly neutral | Leaning positive | 9 |
| Governance and the new state | 1% (-1 pts) | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 9 |
| Refugees and return | 0% (+0 pts) | Leaning negative | Leaning positive | 3 |
| Coast and Alawite communities | 0% (+0 pts) | Mostly neutral | Mostly neutral | 3 |

### Tone by day

| | People | Outlets | Posts analysed |
|---|---|---|---|
| 19 October 2026 | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 4,538 |
| 20 October 2026 | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 4,337 |
| 21 October 2026 | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 4,053 |
| 22 October 2026 | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 5,694 |
| 23 October 2026 | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 3,629 |
| 24 October 2026 | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 3,675 |
| 25 October 2026 | Leaning negative | Mostly neutral | 3,710 |

Each update analyses a sample of up to 800 posts from the previous 24 hours, so one post can be counted in several updates. Compare days with each other rather than reading the figures as numbers of posts.

## 3. People and the media

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### What people talked about most

1. Israeli incursions, checkpoints and olive grove bulldozing continue in Quneitra and Daraa 6% of people's posts on average
2. Chants controversy at Wehda-Karama basketball match ignites nationwide anger 5% of people's posts on average
3. Fears of Israeli-backed Druze offensive against government forces in Suwayda 4% of people's posts on average
4. Internal Security forces target ISIS cell in Rankous, rural Damascus 2% of people's posts on average
5. Public anger over prices and exchange rate volatility in Aleppo and beyond 2% of people's posts on average

### What the media and experts focused on

- **Security:** Israeli incursions dominate a week of overlapping security crises
- **Economy:** Reform Momentum Meets Diesel Shortages and Graft Probes
- **Governance:** Reshuffles, repeals and unresolved property rights define governance week

### How they compare

The comparison between media/expert coverage and ordinary Syrians' own posts shows broad agreement on the dominant subjects, Israeli incursions, Sweida tensions, economic hardship, but sharp divergence in tone and emphasis. Syrians' posts on Israeli incursions carried markedly sharper anger (around -0.47) than the more measured official condemnations carried in SANA and Syria TV, while Sweida-related posts revealed openly sectarian divisions defending or attacking Sheikh al-Hijri that most media coverage described more neutrally as 'outlaw groups' blocking roads. Public skepticism toward the official Rankous ISIS narrative, reflected in the prominence of a public denial, also went further than most outlets, which largely transmitted the interior ministry's account.

People: ordinary Syrians' own posts and comments on the tracker, outlets not counted.
Media and experts: our analysis of Syrian and international media, think tanks and international organisations.

## 4. What the media and experts said

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### The overall picture: Incursions, Reform Pledges and Unresolved Property Rights

**In short:** This week's media and expert coverage converged on expanding Israeli military activity across southern Syria, a cluster of international financing deals presented as a turning point for recovery, and a cabinet reshuffle alongside unresolved property and minority-rights questions. Across all three areas, formal institutional narratives of sovereignty, reform and transition sat uneasily against documented shortages, graft investigations and contested security operations on the ground.

A thread runs across security, economy and governance this week: formal state and international narratives of progress and sovereignty are repeatedly qualified by documentation of contested conduct on the ground. Syrian officials and UN representatives condemned Israeli incursions in Quneitra and Daraa as sovereignty violations, while Etana counted roughly 3,200 ground operations since December 2024, suggesting an entrenched pattern rather than isolated episodes. Similarly, the START trust fund and a first letter of credit in over a decade were framed as milestones even as Syrian Observatory for Human Rights and Syrian outlets documented diesel shortages and currency instability. The governance reshuffle splitting industry from the economy ministry was presented as modernisation, even as Zaman al-Wasl published names tied to a broad presidential audit of the oil sector.

Security coverage this week was dominated by Israeli military activity, but the material also shows competing foreign rationales operating in parallel: US envoy Tom Barrack called for Israeli operations to stop while seeking a security agreement, and Turkey's defence minister insisted its forces would remain until border security is guaranteed. The Israeli think tank INSS read Syrian protests against incursions as strategically risky for Israel, a framing at odds with Syrian coverage describing the same protests as patriotic unity. This divergence suggests that while Syrian, regional and international sources agree incursions are intensifying, they disagree sharply on what the protests and diplomacy mean for Israel's calculus.

Economic coverage reveals a split between macro-financial diplomacy and ground-level distress that recurs almost identically in the governance sphere. International financial institutions and Gulf lenders presented the WB-IMF trust fund and Saudi concessional lending as central achievements, while The Syria Report cited experts estimating three to five years before Syria's anti-money laundering regime meets international standards, a caveat largely absent from celebratory state coverage. The contrast between SANA calling the fund 'a pillar for recovery' and Al-Watan Online calling it 'a conditional opportunity tied to reform' captures a broader tension between optimism from international and state-aligned sources and caution from independent Syrian outlets.

Corruption investigations connect the economy and governance threads directly: the overhaul of the Petroleum Company and Sovereign Fund leadership, reported widely by The Syria Report and Al-Watan Online, coincided with Zaman al-Wasl's detailed reporting on frozen assets and travel bans tied to a presidential audit. This pattern, appointments presented as reform paired with investigations into the officials being replaced, suggests the transitional government is simultaneously trying to demonstrate accountability and manage internal patronage networks, a tension that Syrian independent outlets scrutinise more than state or international sources.

Governance coverage this week highlighted unresolved property rights as a recurring friction point: parliament's repeal of the education ministry's seizure law left open what happens to already-seized properties, per Syria TV, while expropriated landowners protested in Berlin and Damascus residents demanded answers over eviction-related demolitions. This sits alongside Kurdish communities' resistance to reduced Kurdish-language instruction, reported by Syria Direct and Hawar News, indicating that questions of who controls land, curriculum and institutional authority remain unsettled across multiple regions, not only in the north-east.

Diplomacy featured heavily across security and governance coverage, with President al-Sharaa's meetings with Tom Barrack and regional visits to Jordan and Bahrain dominating volume. Barrack's remarks on a Druze sheikh drew sharp pushback from Sheikh al-Hijri, reported by Enab Baladi, illustrating that even diplomatic outreach intended to stabilise relations with minority communities can generate friction when perceived as external interference in local legitimacy questions.

Looking at the sources together, a clear divide emerges between international and state-aligned actors emphasising macro-level achievements (financing deals, cabinet appointments, diplomatic engagements) and independent Syrian and rights-monitoring outlets documenting the uneven, sometimes contested reality beneath those headlines (fuel shortages, extrajudicial killings, property disputes, minority grievances). This divide is not simply optimism versus pessimism but reflects different scales of analysis: institutions assess structural progress while independent and local reporting tracks daily consequences and accountability gaps.

For the coming period, the material suggests three fault lines to watch: whether financial normalisation steps (FATF exit, bond issuance, trust fund disbursement) translate into tangible relief given the three-to-five-year compliance timeline cited by The Syria Report; whether Israeli incursions provoke further Syrian protest movements that INSS's analysis suggests could carry costs for Israel; and whether unresolved property, education and Kurdish-language questions harden into broader governance crises given the recurring, unresolved nature of each across weeks of coverage.

### Security: Israeli incursions dominate a week of overlapping security crises

**In short:** Syrian, regional and international sources this week converged on a single dominant story: expanding Israeli military activity in southern Syria, from daily incursions and detentions in Quneitra and Daraa to drone flights over Damascus and an advance into Mount Hermon. Alongside this, a contested security operation against an ISIS cell in Rankous and renewed blockades in Sweida kept questions of state authority and accountability in focus.

Syrian outlets including SANA (state-run), Al-Watan Online, Syria TV and Enab Baladi (independent), along with the Syrian Observatory for Human Rights (a UK-based monitoring group), documented near-daily Israeli incursions into Quneitra and Daraa throughout the week: shelling near Tal al-Ahmar al-Sharqi and Abidin, road closures at Hader-Tranja, detentions of shepherds and young men, and the uprooting of around 400 olive trees, according to Syria TV. Etana records roughly 3,200 ground operations in the demilitarized zone and Syrian territory since December 2024, describing an expanding Israeli footprint in the south-west. SOHR adds that Israeli forces advanced into Mount Hermon amid continued drone flights over Damascus, Daraa and Sweida.

The killing of a young man with a disability during an incursion into western Daraa drew wide condemnation: SANA reports the foreign ministry condemned the killing, the UN called on Israel to respect Syria's sovereignty, and deputy UN special envoy Claudio Cordone made the same appeal according to Syria TV. Days later, Enab Baladi and others reported the Israeli army killed another young man during an incursion in Daraa countryside, underscoring a civilian toll that Syrian officials and UN representatives frame as violations of sovereignty and international law, a view echoed by an international law expert cited by Al-Watan Online.

Protests against Israeli incursions spread across multiple provinces, including Daraa, Raqqa and Qalamoun, framed by SANA and Hawar News (affiliated with the Kurdish-led Autonomous Administration) as expressions of Syrian unity and sovereignty; Al-Watan Online similarly describes 'popular solidarity from Qalamoun to Daraa.' The Israeli think tank INSS separately analyses these protests as an unusual, strategically risky development for Israel, suggesting Israeli analysts see domestic political costs to the incursions that Syrian coverage frames purely as patriotic unity.

US envoy Tom Barrack was repeatedly cited (North Press, Syria TV, ANHA, affiliated with the Autonomous Administration) calling for Israeli military operations in Syria to stop and saying Washington seeks a security agreement, signalling a US diplomatic push distinct from the Syrian government's framing of outright sovereignty violations. The Foundation for Defense of Democracies (a pro-Israel-aligned Washington think tank) separately argued that Turkey's own justification for its military presence in Syria does not hold up, while Turkey's defence minister, cited by North Press and Syria TV, insisted Turkish forces would remain in Syria and Iraq until border security is guaranteed, pointing to competing foreign military rationales operating in parallel to the Israeli one.

A contested security operation in Rankous against an alleged ISIS cell, reported by SANA, Syria TV and Al-Watan Online, left seven dead according to Syria TV, with the interior ministry citing precise intelligence (Zaman al-Wasl) while local residents in Enab Baladi's coverage protested demanding government clarification and a named figure (al-Tali) publicly denied any connection to the operation. SOHR separately documents 36 extrajudicial killings since early 2026 over alleged ties to the former Assad regime, and reports thousands held in transitional government prisons amid allegations of torture, suggesting a wider pattern of contested security conduct beyond Rankous alone that rights monitors are tracking.

Sweida saw renewed closures of its main highway to Damascus, described by SANA and Zaman al-Wasl as actions by 'outlaw groups,' with a US envoy voicing concern over armed groups there according to SANA, while Al-Watan Online cites a local figure (Leith al-Balous) saying improved Damascus-Sweida movement displeases those seeking to destabilise the province. Syria TV frames the issue through electoral calculations keeping the 'Sweida file' open, indicating Syrian outlets see the province as a site of contested political and security maneuvering rather than a simple law-and-order matter.

On the ISIS threat more broadly, the Washington Institute (a US think tank focused on Middle East policy) argues an emboldened Iran could trigger a resurgence of the Islamic State, while Kurdish-affiliated outlets Hawar News and ANHA both ask, nine years after Raqqa's liberation, whether ISIS could still return, and SOHR reports four SDF brigades completed training as part of integration with the Syrian Defence Ministry, a step some may see as strengthening counter-ISIS capacity even as the threat question remains open.

War remnants and chemical weapons justice also featured: SOHR reports 11 children killed or injured by war remnants since early October, with Syria TV separately reporting two brothers killed by a war-remnant explosion in Daraa countryside, while the independent outlet Enab Baladi examines prospects for justice for thousands of victims of Syria's chemical weapons attacks, and the ICRC calls for repatriating children and young people from camps and prisons in north-east Syria and Iraq, pointing to unresolved humanitarian and accountability questions that receive less day-to-day coverage than the Israeli incursions.

#### Where they agree

Syrian state, independent and Kurdish-affiliated outlets alike, along with SOHR and UN representatives cited in this material, broadly agree that Israeli incursions in the south constitute violations of Syrian sovereignty requiring international attention, and that they are intensifying rather than subsiding. There is also broad agreement across SANA, Syria TV, Enab Baladi and Hawar News that the resulting civilian protests reflect genuine popular rejection of these incursions.

#### Where they differ

Sources diverge on the Rankous operation: the interior ministry and SANA present it as a precise intelligence-led success against ISIS, while Enab Baladi's reporting of local protests and a named denial from al-Tali suggests skepticism about the official account. Think tanks also differ on regional military presences: the Foundation for Defense of Democracies questions Turkey's justification for its presence, while Turkish officials cited by North Press and Syria TV defend it as necessary for border security, and US envoy Barrack's calls to halt Israeli operations contrast with the absence of any comparable Israeli acknowledgement in this material.

#### Recommendations

- The ICRC calls on relevant authorities to repatriate children and young people held in camps and prisons in north-east Syria and Iraq.
- Deputy UN special envoy Claudio Cordone and UN representatives call on Israel to respect Syria's sovereignty following the killing of civilians during incursions.
- US envoy Tom Barrack calls on Israel to halt its military operations in Syria and urges progress toward a bilateral security agreement.
- Syrian organisations and activists call on the Syrian government and international community to act against Israeli incursions and call for public protests.
- An international criminal law expert cited by Al-Watan Online outlines accountability options for Israeli violations in southern Syria for relevant legal and governmental bodies.

### Economy: Reform Momentum Meets Diesel Shortages and Graft Probes

**In short:** International financial institutions and Syrian state media portrayed October 2026 as a turning point, with a new World Bank-backed recovery fund, a first letter of credit in over a decade, and Gulf investment pledges. But Syrian outlets and the Syrian Observatory for Human Rights documented a parallel reality of fuel shortages, currency instability, wheat payment delays, and corruption investigations that left the recovery narrative contested.

International financial institutions and governments presented a cluster of reconstruction financing deals as the period's central development. The Syria Report reported the WB-IMF annual meetings concluded with a multi-donor trust fund and USD 406 million in Saudi concessional lending, while The Syria Report and Syrian outlets including Enab Baladi, Halab Today and regional media such as The National, Arab News and Qatar's Arab News all covered the joint Syria-World Bank statement establishing the Syria Recovery and Reconstruction Trust Fund (START). State-run SANA quoted economic experts calling the fund 'a pillar for recovery', while independent Al-Watan Online described it more cautiously as 'a conditional opportunity tied to reform.' The Lebanese-based pan-Arab Al Akhbar, which is critical of the Syrian government, argued the fund and related decrees let President al-Sharaa distribute economic posts to close associates.

Financial normalisation steps multiplied but came with caveats about scale and oversight. Enab Baladi examined Syria's continued placement on the FATF grey list and possible exit strategies, while Enab Baladi reported the central bank governor promising an imminent exit and Halab Today quoted an official saying the exit is 'a matter of time'; The Syria Report cited experts estimating that bringing Syria's anti-money laundering regime to international standards could take three to five years. Enab Baladi also reported JPMorgan helped Syria secure a letter of credit to buy fuel from Saudi Aramco, covered too by Syria TV, framed as the first such instrument in over a decade. Enab Baladi separately analysed what Syria's return to the IMF's Arab group changes economically, while the finance ministry's plan to issue foreign bonds, reported by Enab Baladi, drew expert commentary on both advantages and risks.

Currency instability and the cost of living dominated domestic economic coverage. The Syrian Observatory for Human Rights reported rising prices and an unstable exchange rate deepening cost-of-living pressures nationwide, while Al-Watan Online put the monthly cost of living for a Syrian family at 13 million liras, prompting debate over minimum wage levels. Al-Watan Online quoted an expert saying central bank currency platforms cannot fully control exchange rates because cash use limits oversight, even as Syria TV and The Syria Report reported the central bank governor and an official statement naming currency and remittance market regulation a top priority. The independent Lebanese-based Al Modon reported the central bank escalating enforcement against exchange market violators. Al-Watan Online asked whether subsidies could ease living costs, reflecting continued uncertainty over policy direction.

A fuel and energy crisis ran through multiple reports as a counterpoint to recovery narratives. The Syrian Observatory for Human Rights reported a fire at the Al-Jabsa oil facility amid the fuel crisis, while Syria TV, Syria TV and Syria TV documented diesel shortages disrupting transport, electricity, agriculture and heating in Aleppo and Latakia; SANA acknowledged the shortage's effect on livelihoods in Aleppo and Idlib. Enab Baladi reported urgent measures involving 250 fuel tankers to address the crisis, even as SANA and regional outlets including Independent Arabia and Al-Araby Al-Jadeed celebrated the arrival of the first Saudi Aramco diesel shipment at Baniyas, a contrast highlighting the gap between high-level energy deals and ground-level shortages.

Corruption investigations into the oil sector were extensively documented by independent outlet Zaman al-Wasl, which published names of individuals with frozen assets and travel bans as part of what it called a broad presidential audit of the oil sector, including deputy Petroleum Company heads Ahmed Qabaji and Walid al-Youssef, and reported the state recovered 80% of businessman Sobhi Abbas's fuel assets. The Syria Report and Al-Watan Online reported the Petroleum Company's leadership was overhauled amid the gasoline scandal, with The Syria Report noting the decree appointing Maher Khalil Al-Hasan as new CEO; international trade outlet Energy Intelligence also reported the sacking. The Sovereign Fund separately denied settling with Yasar Ibrahim, per Syria TV and Zaman al-Wasl, while pledging public review of its assets per Enab Baladi.

Agricultural sector distress featured prominently in Syrian outlet coverage. Al-Jumhuriya, an independent outlet, reported delayed wheat payments freezing markets in the Jazira region, while Enab Baladi reported the Agricultural Bank mobilising branches and setting deadlines to settle wheat payments owed to farmers. North Press, affiliated with areas administered by the Kurdish-led Autonomous Administration, reported a better olive harvest on the Syrian coast but rising financial burdens on farmers and workers, and separately North Press reported rising prices shrinking winter food stocks for coastal families. Hawar News, also linked to the Autonomous Administration, examined the uncertain future of the Agricultural Cooperative Bank amid unpaid dues and stalled financing, while Syria TV and its follow-up Syria TV warned that roughly 22,000 unregulated wells and prolonged drought are depleting groundwater in Idlib and Aleppo.

Foreign investment courtship continued across multiple fronts, with Syrian state media emphasising diplomatic economic outreach. SANA and SANA reported Syrian-Saudi talks on investment, real estate, customs and logistics cooperation, while SANA reported talks with Germany and Syria TV and SANA reported Qatari-French pledges to support stability and recovery. Enab Baladi reported 20 foreign car companies seeking market entry, and Enab Baladi reported Mastercard launching a digital payments gateway. The Syria Report argued Syria's political transition reopened the market to German and European firms amid reconstruction needs estimated at $216 billion, a scale against which actual realised investment remained limited according to most Syrian coverage.

Labour market and social indicators drew scrutiny from Syrian outlets probing whether growth was reaching ordinary people. Syria TV and Enab Baladi reported the statistics authority launching a national labour force survey to monitor unemployment, while The Syrian Observer, an independent outlet, investigated who is withholding billions in liquidity from the Syrian economy. Syria Direct, an independent Syrian-Jordanian outlet, reported that despite Syria's reconnection to global finance, ordinary Syrians still struggle with rising living costs and slow reforms; Enab Baladi reported high private university tuition fees prompting student complaints, and Zaman al-Wasl reported poor Aleppo residents demanding restoration of a displaced market that had harmed vendors' livelihoods.

#### Where they agree

Syrian state media, think tanks like The Syria Report, and international outlets broadly agree that 2026 marked a significant reopening of Syria to international finance, citing the START fund, FATF engagement, and renewed foreign credit lines as concrete milestones. Nearly all sources, including Al-Watan and Enab Baladi, agree that implementation and oversight, not announcements, will determine whether these deals matter, as seen in shared caution about corruption risks around the Petroleum Company and Sovereign Fund.

#### Where they differ

Sources diverge sharply on how to interpret leadership reshuffles and new institutions: SANA and allied experts frame the Petroleum Company and Sovereign Fund changes as reform, while the Lebanese Al Akhbar argues they amount to patronage distribution among al-Sharaa's associates. Independent outlets like Zaman al-Wasl and the Syrian Observer emphasize unresolved corruption and withheld liquidity as central problems, a more skeptical frame than the largely celebratory coverage of financing deals found in SANA and some regional media like Arab News.

#### Recommendations

- Enab Baladi's reporting on the FATF grey list implies the Syrian government should pursue concrete anti-money laundering reforms rather than rely on optimistic timelines to achieve delisting.
- The Syria Report's analysis of anti-money laundering standards suggests international partners should set realistic multi-year expectations for Syria's financial sector reform.
- Al-Watan Online's framing of the recovery fund as conditional suggests donors and the World Bank should attach clear reform benchmarks to START fund disbursements.
- Zaman al-Wasl's extensive reporting on frozen assets implies Syrian authorities should ensure the presidential audit of the oil sector proceeds transparently and extends accountability broadly.
- Al-Jumhuriya and Enab Baladi's coverage of delayed wheat payments suggests the Agricultural Bank should prioritize timely disbursement to prevent market freezes in grain-producing regions.
- The Syrian Observer's investigation into withheld liquidity implies policymakers should identify and address structural barriers keeping capital out of the formal economy.

### Governance: Reshuffles, repeals and unresolved property rights define governance week

**In short:** Coverage this week centred on a cabinet reshuffle splitting industry from economy, parliament's repeal of a law letting the education ministry seize property, and continued scrutiny of expropriation and transitional justice processes. Syrian outlets across the spectrum gave heavy attention to diplomatic meetings, especially with US envoy Tom Barrack, while property, education and minority-language grievances recurred as unresolved governance tests.

The transitional government underwent a notable reshuffle: The Syria Report and Syria Report detail decrees appointing Omar Samer Al-Halabi as Economic Affairs Adviser and chairman of the Sovereign Fund, and Basel AbdulAziz AbdulHanan as Minister of Industry, Internal Trade and Consumer Protection, confirmed by SANA (state-run) and Enab Baladi (independent). The Syrian Observer frames this as splitting industry from the economy ministry entirely, while Syria TV analyses the appointments' significance for industry, oil and the sovereign fund together. The Syria Report lists the resulting 24-member cabinet. Commentary in Syria TV argues loyalty alone cannot run the administration, calling for competence alongside political allegiance.

Parliament repealed a law allowing the education ministry to seize real estate, reported by SANA, Zaman al-Wasl and the Youth Dialogue Forum (Youth Dialogue Forum). Syria TV raises the unresolved question of what happens to properties already seized, and a separate Syria TV piece asks whether broader expropriation law reform could restore property rights. Enab Baladi reports Law 41 is before parliament with demands to lift restrictions on border property ownership, while Zaman al-Wasl covers expropriated landowners protesting outside the Syrian embassy in Berlin, and the Syrian Observatory for Human Rights (Syrian Observatory for Human Rights) reports Damascus residents demanding answers after eviction-related demolitions.

Education governance drew sustained criticism: the Syrian Observatory (Syrian Observatory for Human Rights) and North Press report concern over curriculum changes and gender segregation, while North Press and Syria TV report controversy over school textbook amendments. Syria Direct, an independent outlet, and Hawar News, affiliated with the Kurdish-led administration, report Kurdish communities resisting reduced Kurdish-language instruction and fearing erosion of identity amid distrust of Damascus. SANA describes the mechanism for integrating northern educational institutions into the national system, and Syria TV and Enab Baladi report the start of merging Turkish-administered university branches into Syrian universities.

Judicial and transitional justice developments feature prominently: Enab Baladi reports 61 cases under review in the transitional justice track, while Syria TV notes the Syrian Network for Human Rights raised concerns about trials of former regime figures. Halab Today reports a judge sentenced for serious violations, and Al-Watan Online quotes the parliamentary constitutional committee head saying Syria needs 7,500 more judges. SANA explains witness testimony rules, and Zaman al-Wasl publishes a document showing a former intelligence branch barred a citizen from leaving Syria despite the regime's fall, illustrating lingering institutional legacies.

Diplomacy dominated coverage volume: multiple Syrian outlets, including SANA, Al-Watan Online, Syria TV and The Syrian Observer, covered President al-Sharaa's meeting with US envoy Tom Barrack, with Barrack quoted by SANA and North Press saying Syria plays a pivotal regional role and an Israel-Syria understanding remains possible. Al-Watan Online and Syria TV report Barrack's remarks on a Druze sheikh, which drew sharp responses: Enab Baladi and Enab Baladi report Sheikh al-Hijri rejecting the idea that Druze legitimacy derives from Washington. Foreign Minister al-Shaibani's regional visits to Jordan and Bahrain were extensively covered by SANA, Syria TV and Al-Watan Online, with The Syrian Observer noting reaffirmed commitment to the Sweida roadmap.

Sweida and minority governance remain contested: Syria TV examines how Suwayda residents view dialogue calls, Syria TV reports the government saying it is ready to rebuild trust with residents, and Al-Watan Online analyses the gap between external reliance and local interests. Al-Watan Online reports Hasakah residents holding a solidarity protest demanding transparency over their province's future. Kurdish political actors, including the Kurdistan National Council's Qere Yilan via Hawar News and the Kurdistan Renewal Movement via Hawar News, call for political struggle to protect Kurdish rights and freedom of party activity, while North Press and North Press report internal crisis within the Kurdistani Yekiti party ahead of its congress.

Civic space and press freedom drew scrutiny: Zaman al-Wasl reports a journalist summoned and interrogated with his phone searched by internal security in Raqqa, and Zaman al-Wasl reports a culture ministry official accusing the outlet of spreading lies over coverage of a minister. Al-Jumhuriya, an independent outlet, examines who controls lawyers' syndicates after Assad, while Syria TV reports the Aleppo Bar Association struck off a lawyer based on complaints. Al-Jumhuriya and Al-Jumhuriya examine how citizens communicate with official institutions, suggesting persistent friction.

Local administration and services saw incremental reporting: SANA reports Alouk station's water declared safe for drinking after tests, Syria TV reports families returning to Ras al-Ain with plans for more returns, and Syria TV reports a new circular authorising provincial oversight bodies to investigate building violations. SANA reports reinstatement of 276 railway employees dismissed for revolutionary participation, and Al-Watan Online reports anticipated international support for digital transformation of state institutions.

#### Where they agree

Syrian outlets across the spectrum, state-run and independent alike, broadly treat the repeal of the education ministry's property seizure law and the cabinet reshuffle as significant governance developments worth sustained coverage. There is also convergence around framing property rights, including expropriation and HLP issues flagged by ReliefWeb, as unresolved despite the fall of the former regime, a view shared by Syria TV, Zaman al-Wasl and the Youth Dialogue Forum.

#### Where they differ

Views diverge over Kurdish education integration: SANA, the state outlet, frames it as administrative streamlining, while Syria Direct and Hawar News frame it as a threat to Kurdish identity and language survival. Sources also differ on US envoy Barrack's role: SANA and North Press relay his statements on Syria's pivotal regional role neutrally, while Enab Baladi and Enab Baladi report sharp Druze pushback against his remarks on a local sheikh.

#### Recommendations

- Housing, Land and Property stakeholders should implement the technical guidance on evictions to protect affected residents, per ReliefWeb.
- Parliament should clarify the status of properties already seized under the repealed education ministry law, as urged implicitly by Syria TV.
- The transitional government should address Kurdish community demands for constitutional recognition of their language, as sought by the initiative covered in Hawar News.
- Authorities should increase judicial appointments to address the shortfall of roughly 7,500 judges identified by Al-Watan Online.
- The government should pursue genuine dialogue and transparency with Sweida and Hasakah residents to rebuild trust, as called for by Al-Watan Online and Syria TV.

## 5. What to watch

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### In what people say

- Whether the Suwayda highway blockade and sectarian rhetoric around Hikmat al-Hijri escalate further, especially after US envoy Barrack's remarks.
- Continued public distrust of the Rankous ISIS narrative and whether authorities release further information to address it.
- Whether diesel shortages ease following emergency shipments, or public anger over fuel and prices keeps rising.
- Coordination signals around the Al Arabiya Druze-identity interview and the Israel-incursion story, worth monitoring without assuming organised origin.

## 6. Sources and method

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